

bridges tradition and innovation in unexpected ways.

Festival director Divya Bhatia sums up RIFF's journey with a line from Marcel Proust—'The real voyage of discovery consists not in seeking new landscapes but in having new eyes.' "We're learning how best to positively impact the livelihood of traditional Rajasthani artists," he says. "And we have done this while keeping programming fresh."

A key highlight this year is En Route, a solo immersive walking experience that turns the fort and city into a living soundscape. "I wanted to develop an artistic experience to connect the audience with the fort and the city in a completely novel way," says Bhatia.

The 2025 lineup features Padma Shri Lakha Khan on the 27-string Sindhi sarangi, Hindustani vocalist Ashwini Bhide Deshpande, Manganiyar maestro Sawan Khan, Poland's Karolina Cicha, Finnish fiddler Emilia Lajunen, Syrian saxophonist Basel Rajoub and Colombian DJ-producer Killabeat-maker. Together, they bring traditions as diverse as fado, shashmaqam, Carnatic fusion and Afro-Latin beats to the desert, creating a truly global musical dialogue.

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The festival is equally celebrated for its late-night jam sessions and the climactic RIFF Rustle, where artists from across traditions come together in spontaneous performance under the Sharad Purnima full moon. "At 18, we have a strong foundation," says Bhatia. "We are just about finding our feet in this ever-evolving live music landscape." ■

—Geetika Sachdev





THE CITY SPEAKS Installations by (left) French sculptor Gaspard Combes and Rajasthani weaver Maina Devi

ART ▼

Artisan Dialogues

JODHPUR ARTS WEEK debuts with global creators and local artisans working on site-responsive works across the city

A Public Arts Trust of India (PATI) initiative, the Jodhpur Arts Week: Edition 1.0 will take place from October 1 to 7. Curated by Tapiwa Matsinde and Sakhshi Mahajan, it brings together more than 20 global artists and designers who have created site-responsive works in dialogue with Jodhpur's artisans, landscapes and communities.

"This year's theme, *Hath Ro Hunar*, honours the artisans whose expertise and labour have shaped Jodhpur's rich cultural fabric," says Sana Rezwan, founding chairwoman, PATI.

While Chila Kumari Singh Burman's site-specific neon installation reimagines Jodhpur's historic stepwells, Puneet Kaushik explores textile traditions as a means of cultural memory and gendered labour. Ayesha Singh's installation reflects on women's role in shaping public architecture and Theo Pinto merges his abstract visual language with Jodhpur's traditional stone- and wood-carving techniques. French artist Gaspard Combes's public sculpture, *Colours of Rajasthan*, will be unveiled in its new location at Mandore Gardens. Abishek Ganesh J. will present a site-specific work at the temple within the Raj Mahal Government Girls School, while Saruha Kilaru presents a new body of work that reimagines the lost legacy of Gulaab Rai. "By weaving together the narratives of contemporary creators, traditional artisans and local communities, we aim to challenge conventional boundaries between art, craft and social practice," says Rezwan. ■

—Neha Kirpal